

Hello Hong Kong

► Warm air means a change in the weather, and summer means travel to many families. For the Chen family, this summer was going to be an exciting time of year. For the first time, they would take the underground train ride from their home in southern China and travel to Hong Kong.

Jackie was very excited about the visit. Jackie Chan, the movie star, was one of his heroes, and he liked to imagine that one day he would meet the famous star from Hong Kong. They would become good friends, smiling and laughing that their names were almost the same.

The family had spent much time learning about Hong Kong. Still, they were surprised at what they found when they got off the train and walked onto the city streets. Old Chinese ways blended with new Western culture, the result of British rule of the island for hundreds of years. The city was totally bilingual. Almost everyone spoke fluently in English and Chinese. Tall buses with two levels of seats whizzed through the busy streets, competing with trams and taxis for passengers. Modern skyscrapers filled the city, and millions of people bustled about their business and their lives. There were cars, but they certainly weren't necessary with all the public transportation readily available.

Rising high beyond the city skyline were steep, green mountains, and much of the island was preserved for parks. However, the family was only treated to the full beauty of Hong Kong Island when they took a ferry ride across Victoria Harbour. From the water, the family could see almost the entire island, including the mountains.

The Chens had a wonderful time exploring the city, shopping and visiting museums. They loved hiking up peaceful, green trails to look out over the island that was part of their homeland. Jackie knew he would return many times. There was so much to see and do that his imagination was set on fire. Maybe someday he would get to meet his hero. In Hong Kong, everything seemed possible.
